

Stay Safe

Kalila: Ynez? Oh my God! It's been... how long? Ten years? More?

Ynez: Yeah... Something like that.

Kalila: I almost didn't recognize you. You always kept your hair down back then. Now, you're a grown woman. How have you been?

Ynez: I've been... okay. I guess.

Kalila: It's so strange running into you here, especially now, with all this happening. How long have you been in the city?

Ynez: Um... A few months. Things aren't that great back home, so...

Kalila: Ugh, yeah, I can imagine. Safer here. I mean, as safe as anywhere can be these days. Are you staying with your aunt like you used to in the summers?

Ynez: No. No, she uh... she— she passed away last year.

Kalila: Oh... wow. I'm sorry, Ynez. She was a kind woman. Always made sure I had everything I needed when I babysat you. First your parents, now your aunt... that's a lot for a girl your age. So, I guess staying here is for the best, right? Safer than your country, y'know with all those... well you know.

Ynez: ... No, Kalila, I don't. What do you mean, exactly?

Kalila: Y'know... I mean, c'mon... it's not exactly peaceful here either, especially after what's happened. But at least we don't have those people from your country running around causing mayhem. That bombing this morning is just unforgiveable. I don't know how they can keep doing this.

Ynez: MY country didn't bomb anyone today!

Kalila: Oh, come on, Ynez. Don't be naïve. We wouldn't have retaliated if your people hadn't attacked us first. This is their fault, and you should just be grateful that you're able to be here and away from those criminals.

Ynez: Criminals? Is that what you think of us? I'm here because your country won't leave mine alone. We're not criminals, Kalila. We're fighting for our lives.

Kalila: Fighting for your lives? How? By killing innocent people? Some defense, Ynez. How many times do you think we can be hit before hitting back? Actions have consequences.

Ynez: YOU attacked us first. YOU! Your side is just louder... more globally accepted. Ha, but I guess the favorable side always gets to decide who is right and who is wrong.

Kalila: That's ridiculous. We're defending ourselves. You know, I can't even believe you're defending them after all they've done.

Ynez: They who? Who are they, Kalila? Give me a name.

Kalila: ...

Ynez: Exactly. We are just people. No groups. No organization. Individuals. Just individuals with lives and loved ones, just like you. My life is not worth less than yours.

Kalila: I didn't say that Ynez.

Ynez: No? You only talk about us like we're terrorists.

Kalila: Not you. Them.

Ynez: ... You just don't get it. And you won't. Because you don't have to. You're too removed from it. How's your life? Husband? Kids? White picket fence? Everything you used to say you wanted.

Kalila: Well maybe if your leaders stopped trying to attack us, you could have that life too.

Ynez: Well maybe if your leaders stopped turning my country into a warzone, I already would've. But that's never going to happen, is it? Not when you all think we're the enemy.

Kalila: Because your side IS the enemy. How else do you explain the constant attacks? It's practically endless.

Ynez: How many attacks have been on your soil compared to ours? Around 1 in 100, maybe.

Kalila: Ynez...

Ynez: It's endless because no one wants to listen. Everyone just wants to blame us and act like they're the victims when you have been attacking us my entire life. I'm not saying we're the picture of innocence, but we're not the only ones with blood on our hands.

Kalila: Ynez... This is pointless. We will never see eye to eye on this.

Ynez: No, we won't.

Kalila: I just... I don't know what else to say. It's disappointing to see you have ended up on the wrong side of this.

Ynez: The wrong side? We barely have a side. In my country, every breath is another fight for survival.

Kalila: Maybe so... But at least I'm surviving on the right side. You're lucky to be here.

Ynez: You aren't surviving though, you're living. I told you. You're too far removed from it all. Your life isn't being endangered. You literally could have anything you want!

Kalila: You know what? Let's just leave it. We're going in circles.

Ynez: My train is almost here anyways.

Kalila: ...

Ynez: Stay safe, okay?

Kalila: Is that some kind of threat?

Ynez: No, Kalila. I just want you to stay safe.